

JWL — Brand Direction, Options and Recommendation

STRATEGY · IRISH MARKET AUDIT · POSITIONING · FIVE ROUTES · THE
RECOMMENDED MARK

An estate agent is paid to get you the best price. A valuer is paid to tell the truth about the price, independent of anyone's interest in the outcome. Everything in this document exists to make that difference visible before a client reads a word of a report.

It runs in one line: the problem, what the market audit found, the positioning that follows from it, the five routes we explored against that positioning, and the single mark we recommend JWL take forward.

1 · THE STRATEGIC PROBLEM

JWL operates in a category where every player already says the same three words: trusted, expert, professional. The audit shows those words have become wallpaper — no competitor's identity is built to communicate what a valuer does differently from an estate agent. That gap is the opportunity, and the name and the symbol are the only levers left to exploit it.

2 · WHAT THE IRISH MARKET AUDIT FOUND

SIGNAL	WHAT THE CATEGORY DOES	IMPLICATION FOR JWL
Naming	Tier-1 and independent firms alike brand under surnames or initials. "Valuers" or "Chartered Surveyors" sits as a descriptor line underneath, never as the logo.	Three initials is exactly right. Plan a permanent, typographically subordinate descriptor.
Iconography	Houses, roofs and keys belong to agents, letting firms and brokers. Valuation and survey practices skew to wordmarks, monograms and abstract geometry.	No house. A roof silhouette files JWL under "selling homes" and undercuts the independence it sells.
Colour	Agency colour is loud and saturated — reds, greens and magentas built for boards and shopfronts. Advisory firms run navy, charcoal and deep green.	Real whitespace in a restrained palette that reads financial, not retail.
Badges	Seals are a native trust cue here — SCSI Valuer Registration, banks, chartered institutes — but they are detail-heavy.	Use a seal as a secondary certification mark for reports and certificates, never as the favicon.

3 · POSITIONING — JUDGEMENT

JWL's number gets relied on by people who do not trust each other — lender, buyer, seller, court, Revenue. The brand's job is to look like the number can be believed before anyone opens the report.

NOT THIS

Warmth, aspiration, finding home. Lifestyle photography of families and front doors. Rounded, approachable type.

THIS INSTEAD

Calibration, rigour, evidence, calm authority under scrutiny. A measurement-and-trust brand, not a homes-and-lifestyle brand.

- 1. **Measurement** — accuracy and method, not opinion or salesmanship.
- 2. **Judgement** — expertise tested in courts, banks and disputes.
- 3. **Independence** — no stake in the transaction. The one claim no agent can make.
- 4. **Institution, not personality** — closer to a chartered body than a high-street shop.

4 · THE DESIGN SYSTEM THAT FOLLOWS

TYPOGRAPHY	COLOUR	DESCRIPTOR	
A confident serif for the wordmark, in the legal-advisory register, with strong tabular numerals for a business whose product is a number. A refined grotesque carries descriptors, labels and report figures.	Ink navy as the institutional base, one brass accent echoing precision instruments, paper and charcoal as neutrals. No pure black or white, and nothing in the agency red / green / magenta field.	"Chartered Property Valuers" is locked beneath the mark in every lock-up — expected by the market, good for search, and never allowed to compete with JWL for attention.	
Ink Navy #12233C	Brass #B08A4A	Paper #FAF7F1	Charcoal #3A3833

5 · THE FIVE ROUTES EXPLORED

Four routes take instruments of measurement as their starting point. One — the Keystone — deliberately tests the house symbol the category defaults to, so the client can see the difference side by side rather than take it on trust.



01 The Datum MEASUREMENT · BRASS

The surveyor's fixed reference point. A grotesque wordmark set over a dimension line ticked at both ends, brass through the centre span — quiet, technical, and unclaimed in this market.



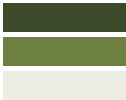
02 The Keystone HOUSE SYMBOL · FOR CONTRAST

Warm, immediately legible as property — and that is the problem. At a glance it reads estate agency, which is the one thing an independent valuer cannot afford. Shown to be ruled out.



03 Plumb Line INDEPENDENCE · BOTTLE GREEN

Gravity decides, not the person holding the string. The strongest single-image argument for independence, though the vertical lock-up is awkward in narrow web headers.



04 The Scale SELECTED · THE MEASURING RULE

Initials measured off against a graduated rule. The route the client selected, and the one developed in full overleaf — refined into ink navy and brass, with the rule set beneath the wordmark.



05 The Target PRECISION · WINE

A ringed crosshair sighted on the number, set beside the wordmark. Shrinks well to a favicon, but the wine red reads closer to the agency palette the audit told us to avoid, and the ring is a symbol where the recommended route uses an instrument.



6 · THE RECOMMENDED MARK — THE MEASURING RULE

Route 04 developed into the identity we recommend: initials sitting directly on a graduated measuring edge, in ink navy with a single brass accent. The rule is the only concession to metaphor and it does real work elsewhere in the system — a header rule on reports, a divider on stationery, a base for signage. There is no image in it to misread at a glance.



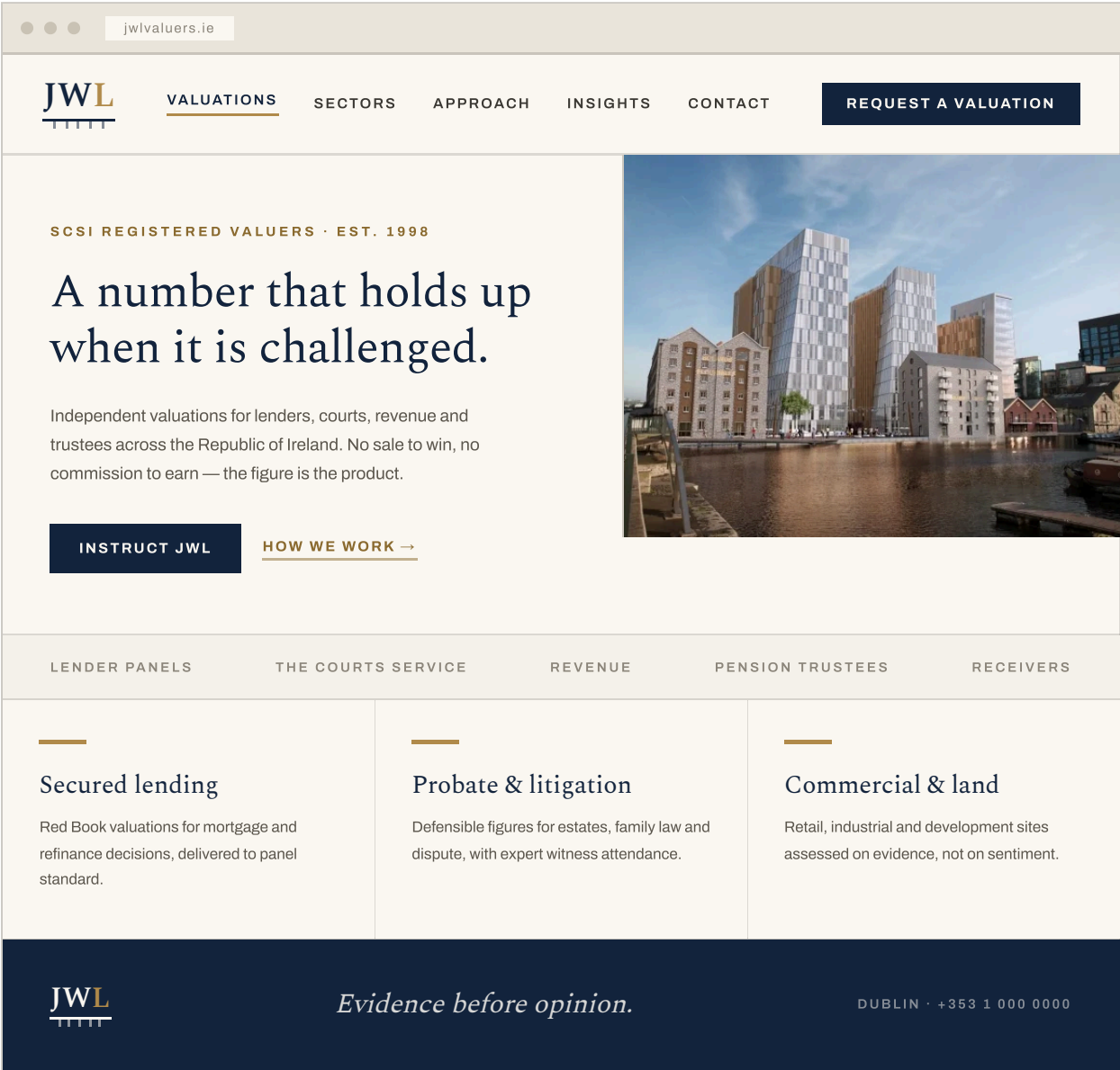
CONSTRUCTION — WHY THE WORDMARK IS CENTRED ON THE RULE

The initials are centred, and the rule is drawn to the width of the wordmark rather than to the width of whatever container it sits in. A rule that runs wider or narrower than the letters reads as a stray line; matched to the wordmark it reads as a measurement *of* JW L — which is the whole idea. Optical centring, not mathematical: the serif on the J and the terminal on the L are aligned to the rule's ends by eye, so it looks square at small sizes.

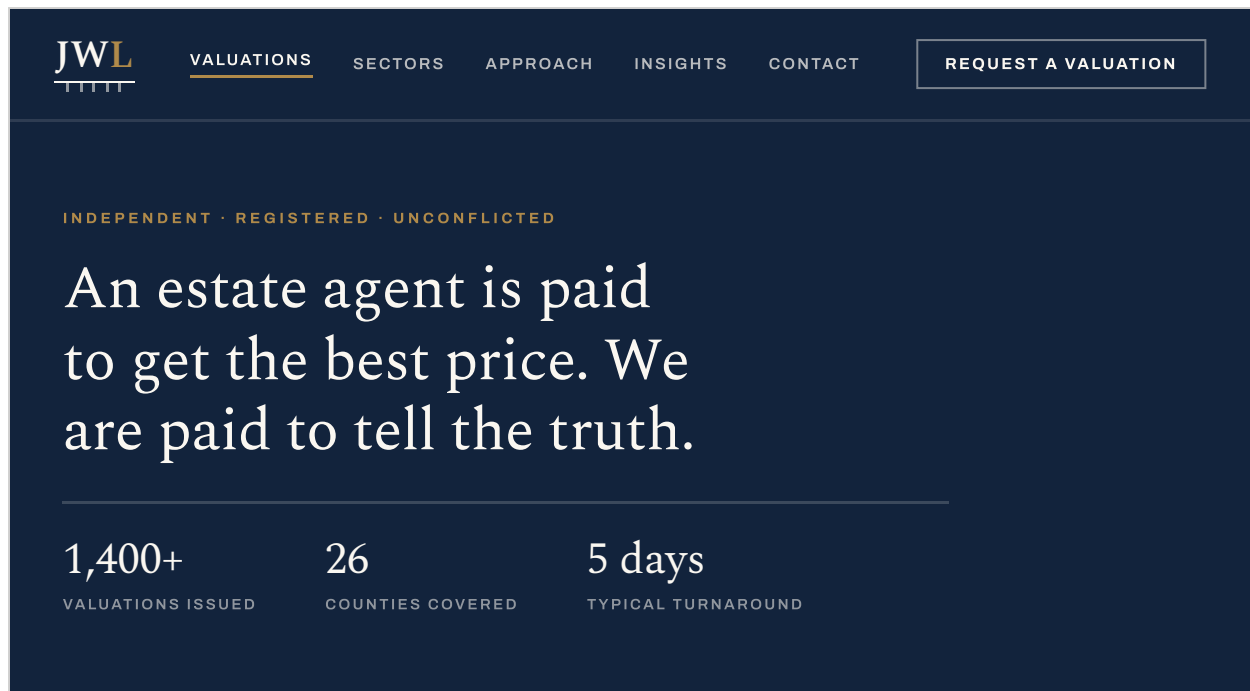
Two further build notes carried over from review: the web lock-up is **unboxed**, because a hard frame fights every container a website already has — the box is reserved for covers, stamps and signage. And the favicon is set in the grotesque rather than the serif, since serifs disappear below roughly ten pixels; the brass rule survives as a 1.5px underline so the idea holds at any size.

6.1 · THE MARK IN CONTEXT — HOMEPAGE

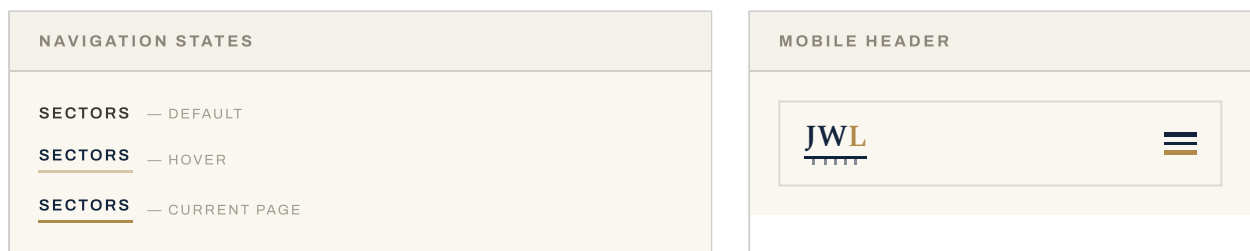
Indicative only — copy is placeholder and the layout is not a sitemap. The purpose is to test how the palette holds at web scale, how much ink navy the page can carry before it turns heavy, and whether the unboxed lock-up survives sitting in a live navigation bar next to five links. Two hero treatments are shown: a paper-ground page that lets the mark do the work, and an ink-ground page that leads on the position.



A — Paper ground. Ink navy is rationed to the navigation lock-up, the headline, one button and the footer band; brass appears three times only. The brass underline on the active nav item is the rule doing navigational work.



B — Ink ground. The same navigation, reversed. Brass carries the eyebrow and the active state; the reversed lock-up needs no box. This treatment leads on the position rather than the imagery and is the stronger option if the site opens with a statement.



C — The rule generalises into interface furniture: it is the hover and current-page indicator, and the third bar of the mobile menu icon. Nothing new has to be invented for the web. The graduations are carried into the web lock-up at six divisions rather than nine — the scale stays legible at navigation size, where nine ticks would fill in and read as a solid bar.

7 · TAGLINE SHORTLIST

LINE	WHAT IT DOES
<i>Evidence before opinion.</i> RECOMMENDED	States the method and the independence in three words, and separates JWL from the salesmanship of the agency world.
<i>Know where you stand.</i>	The most human line of the set. Speaks to the client's actual need, and pairs naturally with the datum idea.
<i>Certainty, on record.</i>	Leans on the formal, documentary side of the work — strong for reports and certification.
<i>Weight behind the number.</i>	Speaks to lenders and courts: the number holds up when it is challenged.
<i>Judgement you can bank on.</i>	Warmest and most commercial of the five. Useful in advertising, less so under the logo.

7.1 · THE OWNED WORD — INITIAL THINKING

Messaging and tone of voice are a separate piece of work and will be delivered in full later. What follows is first thinking only: the one word the brand should try to own, and a head-to-head on the two lines that do the most work.

THE ONE WORD WE OWN

Judgement ■

No initials to explain, no backronym to defend. Judgement is the thing a valuer is actually paid for — not data, not an estimate, but a defensible opinion signed by a named person. It is also the one claim a portal, an algorithm or an agent's appraisal cannot make.

WHERE IT EARNS ITS KEEP

- 01 **The About page opens on it.** One paragraph on what judgement means in a valuation, and who is exercising it.
- 02 **It answers the price question.** When a cheaper quote comes up, the reply is that you are buying judgement, not a form.
- 03 **It sits in the report.** A short signed statement of judgement ahead of the figure, in the valuer's own name.
- 04 **It never appears in the logo.** Owned in language, not locked into the mark — so the lock-up stays clean at every size.

TAGLINE SHORTLIST — HEAD TO HEAD

01

RECOMMENDED AS PRIMARY

Evidence before opinion.

It names the method, and the order of the method — the figure follows the evidence, never the other way round. That is the whole difference between a valuation and an appraisal, and it is the sentence that answers a challenge in court or on a lender's panel. It also disciplines the owned word: judgement here is not instinct, it is evidence read by someone qualified to read it.

Pairs strongest with Route 04, the measuring rule — both say the reading was taken, not guessed. *Know where you stand.* is held in reserve as the warmer client-facing line.

03

BEST AS SHORT-FORM

Sure ground.

Two words, quietly Irish, and the most ownable line of the five — nobody else in the market has anything this short. The trade-off is that it is a mood rather than a promise, and it leans faintly agricultural, which either helps or narrows depending on the mix of work.

Excellent on signage, a site board, a social avatar or an email sign-off, where two words beat five.

They are not mutually exclusive. **Evidence before opinion.** carries the formal end — letterhead, report covers, the website, the signature block on a valuation — with **Sure ground.** as the short line for signage and social. If only one survives, keep 01: it states the method, where 03 only sets a mood. *Know where you stand.* stays on the bench as the softer line for client-facing marketing, where the method matters less than the reassurance.

Four questions every route was tested against before it left the studio. Ask them again in the room:

- Could this be mistaken for an estate agent's logo at a glance?
- Does it survive at 16px, and on an embossed or foiled report cover?
- Does the palette separate JWL from the big Irish agency brands, or blend in?
- Does the mark say measurement and judgement — or does it say home?